Grey Gardens

By Doug Wright, Scott Frankel and Michael Korie

EDITH: **(Pg 62)** Edie? Edie!!

EDIE: **(Pg 2)** I've found it, Mother Darling! I found your old record! *(puts record on the record player and begins singing)*

She is the girl
Who has everything.

EDITH: *EVERRRYTHING!!*

EDIE: *She has the world on a string*

EDITH: *ON A STRRR-ING!*

EDIE: *(appears from off stage. She primps, looking at herself in a hand mirror)* Isn't it wonderful?

EDITH: I recorded it in 1941. I was very serious about my singing; loved it!

INTRODUCTION

Welcome to the private world of the Beale ladies, outcasts of a wealthy and famously dysfunctional branch of the Kennedy dynasty—the Bouvier-Beales. Little Edie, born in 1917 was the family beauty, "surpassing even the dark charm of Jacqueline," She was her mother's crown jewel. Her debutante party in New York City was covered by The New York Times. She dated Howard Hughes and turned down marriage proposals from JFK's oldest brother Joe Jr. and millionaire J. Paul Getty. They lived the life of American Royalty until Little Edie's father left, divorcing her mother by telegram, from Mexico. He left his ex-wife Grey Gardens, a spectacular 28-room mansion with a view of the ocean. And this is where the story becomes something from a gothic novel. And this is where the story becomes something from a gothic novel.

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EDIE: **(Pg 69)** Just listen to this! *(as Edie speaks, Edith begins to prepare dinner for the feral cats living in their house)* The Hamptons Bee. July 1972. "The elderly, bed-ridden Aunt of former first lady Jacqueline Kennedy, Mrs. Edith Bouvier Beale and her adult daughter, Miss Edie Beale, a former debutante, are living on Long

Island in a garbage-ridden, filthy, 28-room room house with fifty-two cats, fleas, cobwebs, and virtually no plumbing. After vociferous complaints from neighbors, the Board of Health took legal action against the reclusive pair" **(Pg 3)** They're calling us "cat ladies."

EDITH: Here kitty!

EDIE: And our house. They're saying Grey Gardens is a "public eyesore."

EDITH: Grey Gardens is one of the most renowned homes in America! *(singing again)* SHE IS THE GIRL WHO HAS EVERYTHING . . .

EDIE: Remember? You sang this song for me. I was "The Girl Who Had Everything" . . . once.

********(Flashback to 1941 – Little Edie's engagement party)********

EDITH: ***(Pg 4-6)*** *SHE IS THE GIRL WHO HAS EVERYTHING . . .*
TALENT AND BEAUTY SUBLIME . . . .!
. . . THE CROWDS AND THE CLAMOR
AROUSED BY HER GLAMOR
WILL FADE LIKE THE ECHO OF A CHIME

EDIE: *(Jumps up and applauds)* Mother Darling, what a charming song!

EDITH: The gift of music for your special day.

EDIE: It's almost too much. Truly. Promise you won't perform it for anyone but me.

EDITH: Why, Edie, whatever do you mean?

EDIE: Well, "The Girl Who Has Everything?" Honestly! What would people think! **(Pg 8)** *(Edie speaks to the audience)* She stopped my cotillion cold and performed all three arias from Faust. My graduation tea . . Carmen with a rose in her teeth. My birthday . . . she danced Salome! Wouldn't it be an odd thing if – on your death certificate – it actually said that you died of shame? **(Pg 16-17)** *(She notices a recital brochure on top of the piano)*

EDIE: *(holding it up)* Why, Mother Darling, what's this?

EDITH: Oh dear. You weren't supposed to see that. It was meant to be a surprise – *(She takes the brochure and admires it)* **(Pg 9)** A musical recital in honor of Miss Edith Bouvier Beal and Mr. Joseph Patrick Kennedy, Jr. the 12th of July, 1941!

EDIE: You're planning to sing?

EDITH: **(Pg 18)** Who knows if we'll ever have another party?

EDIE: It's just that Joe's parents are coming, and they're so terribly New England. I don't expect they listen to music at all.

EDITH: Nonsense! I'm sure they'd be delighted. *(Both characters overlapping)*

EDIE: **(Pg 19)** Decorum, Mother, that's all I ask! . . .

EDITH: Decorum? Oh, that's rich! You're a fine one to lecture me about propriety!

EDIE: When she doesn't get exactly what she wants, she positively spits venom!

EDITH: Wearing lipstick to school- "temptation red" - at only thirteen; the whole town was talking!

EDIE: Pish posh, mother! You'll say anything to be a dramatic, anything to garner attention.

EDITH: This very house was positively blanketed in adolescent shame.

EDIE: **(Pg 20)** Who's engagement is this anyway? *(Beat, then regretfully)* **(Pg 39-40)** Mother, I-

EDITH: Don't! *(She puts down the brochure quietly on the table, spirit broken)*

EDIE: *(Edie feels horrible and picks up some sheet music from the piano – softly)* Is this [one] on the bill? It's one of my favorites.

EDITH: *(Interrupting)* Edie. Please.

EDIE: It's the very first song you ever taught me. We used to sing it together.

EDIE: **(Pg 41)** *(Singing – Edith perks up throughout the song)*

WE'RE A BOWL OF PEACHES AND CREAM
THE DODGERS AND BROOKLYN
A PERMANENT TEAM
INDIA AND GANDHI
DAGWOOD AND HIS BLONDIE

TWO PEAS IN A POD

EDITH: **(Pg 43)** Oh, Edie. I've been monstrously selfish. All eyes should be on you, darling. You and Mr. Kennedy. *(Edie exits – While Edith entertains the crowd including EDIE's fiancée with a story)* **(Pg 50)** Exquisite diver, our Edie . . . Her swimming costume clung to her like skin on a peach. Well, she went sailing into the water . . . and the seams split. Well, a lesser girl would've shrieked and run for cover. But not Edie! She swam the length of the pool. Twice! And when she climbed out, Mr. Kennedy, no one offered her even a towel. Edie walked right past them! She became the most talked about girl in town!

EDIE: *(to audience - horrified)* **(Pg 52)** What? No! She didn't . . . she wouldn't!

TRANSITION

From 1947 to 1952, Little Edie lived at the Barbizon Hotel for Women in New York City, hoping to land her "big break" in show business. Max Gordon, the successful Broadway producer, saw potential in Edie and invited her to audition for the Theatre Guild that summer. But it was not to be. In 1952, Big Edie called on Little Edie to return home from NYC. Her health was poor, and she needed someone to take care of her. For the next two decades, Edie and her mother lived in a fantasy world of their own creation. Re-living the past and ignoring the squalor

EDIE: *(she speaks to the audience as she is feeding a hoard of cats)* **(Pg 79)** I think the saddest thing was my not marrying. I missed out on everything . . .

EDITH: **(Pg 83)** Edieee!!!!

EDIE: I'm feeding the cats!! . . . *(to herself)* When am I going to get OUT of here??

EDITH: **(Pg 84)** EDIEEEE! **(Pg 102)** You know what I'd like? Some music. I'm happier when I'm singing than anything I've ever done since I was born. See if you can find . . . that song. The one I just adore . . .

EDIE: Oh, sure. *(bitterly)* "The Girl Who has Everything"

EDITH: No, heaven's no . . . the flipside *(Edith sings mean-spiritedly)*

(Pg 80) IS IT MY FAULT THAT
YOUR CAKE FELL FLAT?

THAT YOU'RE UNMARRIED
BALD AND FAT?
AS THE WORLD WALTZED BY
AND EDIE SAT . . . .

EDIE: **(Pg 80)** Sometimes I think I have the saddest life . . .

EDITH: **(Pg 128)** Oh, Edie! Wouldn't you like a cup of soup? With some oyster crackers? Wouldn't it be too divine? Have a cup of soup with your mother won't you?

EDIE: Which would you like, Mother Darling? The cream of tomato or the bisque?

EDITH: You choose.

(Edie notices the old record player and crosses to it, raises the lid, flips the record over and drops the arm. She then turns to her mother. She sways to the music and sings with a recording of her younger self)

EDIE: Will youuuu? **(Pg 112)** The last time I performed this song . . . when was it?

EDIE and EDITH TOGEHER: *Will youuuuu? (Edith stops singing. She looks at Edie disapproving)*

EDITH: You're singing it incorrectly. Very ugly.

EDIE: *Will youuuuuu?*

EDITH: **(pg 113)** That's not it! You're waaaaay off. Go to the bottom of the class! Everything is perfectly disgusting on account of you! Bring me my radio? I have got to have some professional music!

EDIE: *(Edie deliberately yanks the needle across the record, scratching it. The music stops)* I stood for you all these years.

EDITH: Well, of course you did! You'd no place else to go –

EDIE: Not true! I was going to the White House! *(Edith shakes her head)* I was! With Mr. Joseph Patrick Kennedy.

EDITH: **(Pg 114)** Pick up a fresh paper: that's yesterday's news!

EDIE: He was keen for me, but you got rid of him because he came from a celebrated family.

EDITH: That's the way! Pin it all on Mama!

EDIE: You got rid of him in fifteen minutes flat

EDITH: You did all that by yourself

EDIE: *(To audience)* She's very mean to me!

EDITH: **(Pg 115)** I didn't want my child to be taken from me! I'd be entirely alone!

EDIE: **(Pg 116-118)** I took care of you! I took care of this damn house for twenty-five years!

EDITH: You didn't have to! After [your father] got his Mexican divorce, I wanted him to come home -- back to Grey Gardens! *(Following lines are spoken over one another as each focuses on their narrative)*

EDIE: As long as my father was alive –

EDITH: So we could be a family again, like other families

EDIE: He wanted to ruin my life!

EDITH: But Edie said "No"

EDIE: I was scared to death of him-

EDITH: She said she'd "leave the house forever"

EDIE: I didn't want him here – screaming at me all the time: Take off that lipstick

EDITH: If Mr. Beale ever came back to Grey Gardens!

EDIE: Wash off that perfume

EDITH: She actually threatened to run away

EDIE: How dare you wear high heels

EDITH: If ***my husband*** - ***her father*** - came back!

EDIE: I didn't need the humiliation

EDITH: Tell the truth, Edie

EDIE: I knew if [he] came back, I'd ***never*** get married!

EDITH: That's not the reason!

EDIE: I'd never find a man!

EDITH: That's not it at all!

EDIE: Mother please!

EDITH: *(angrily warning)* Edie! *(delicately now)* You needed to come home . . .

EDIE: *(Steely and silent. Too much has been said. She plucks the radio up and takes it to her mother. Her voice is strained)* Your radio, Mother Darling. *(Edie exits)*

EDIE: **(Pg 123)** *(In the front yard, she stops at the garden gate)*
Sings:
NEW WORLD AWAIT
JUST FLIP THE LATCH
AND THROUGH THE GATE
GO THROUGH THE GATE
THE GARDEN GATE
MY MOTHER'S GATE

(She stands, frozen. Try as she might, she cannot bring herself to flip the gate latch)

EDITH: **(Pg 127)** *(As Edie stands mute and silent, from upstairs, we hear the familiar cry)* Edie! What have you done? Where have you gone? *(The call cuts through EDIE like a knife, but she does her damnedest to ignore it)* I'm all alone! Edie! The radio; it's gone dead. *(Edie shudders in the evening air)* Edie! I'm starving! I want my supper. I need your help!

EDIE: *(A sigh of resignation and then)* Coming, Mother Darling!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
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The complete musical can be viewed at
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tsPo8g-kj2w
and may be helpful in the development of the lyrics and music for the singing parts of this cutting as well important data for background research.